

The first animals

Fossils tell us that animal life began about 600 million years ago. The first animals lived in darkness, rooted to the seabed, and had simple, soft bodies shaped like disks or leaves, with which they gathered nutritious chemicals or particles in the water. These strange beings seem to have had no legs, no heads, no mouths, no sense organs, and no internal organs.



FIRST LIFE

For nearly nine-tenths of the Earth's history, there were no animals or plants. During most of this early era, called the Precambrian period, the only life forms were microscopic single cells. Some grew in colonies on the sea floor, building up over time to form cushion-shaped mounds of rock – "stromatolites" – that still form today.

*Living stromatolites
in Australia*

